Today, I stand before you to discuss a matter of profound importance, a sentiment that runs deep within Kentucky during this critical time in our nation's history: reasons to distrust Abraham Lincoln. We are at a time when Lincoln has just assumed the presidency, delivering his first inaugural address on March 4th. This is a period of intense fury between the North and South over the institution of slavery, a time when Southern states are actively seceding, and having elected their own leader who made his First Inaugural Address. We Kentuckians are on the pinnacle of this unrest, and although Lincoln claims to be neutral regarding slavery, us slave holding Kentuckians should not trust him.

As Lincoln delivered his first inaugural address, his words might have seemed reassuring, suggesting he did not oppose slavery, but can we really trust these words? If his past is any indication, his statements could be pure deception, possibly designed to ease us into a false sense of security, allowing him to take our property. He has been in the Republican party his entire political career, a party dedicated to pushing back on the rights of the South. One such example is at the Freeport Debate, where Lincoln himself actively pushed the existing Southern right established by the Dred Scott decision, and greatly limited Southern expansion. This is a man whose entire public life is built on undermining the very rights and property that we hold. To suggest we should trust that he won't interfere is extremely naive. Lincoln's statement to not interfere with slavery is nothing more than a shallow promise said by a crooked, lying politician. The deep South harbors a profound suspicion that his promise is flimsy, designed to buy time or disarm the South while he consolidates power.

Another significant reason that Lincoln is not trustworthy is his contradictory stance on denying secession rights. He claims to be a neutral peacekeeper, seeking to preserve the Union, yet he explicitly denies the fundamental right of states to secede. As he stated in his inauguration speech, his actions clearly indicate that he is not a peacekeeper, but rather an aggressor. If he were truly neutral, he would recognize the South's grievances and our inherent right to secede. His outlawing of secession implies that he views the seceded states as being in rebellion, not as sovereign entities exercising their rights. Following this logic, it means he would rather force a war than engage in peaceful negotiation and resolution. It means, at the very least, that Lincoln is a deceitful liar, willing to despair his country to achieve his goals. His entire goal, if realized, will absolutely destroy the economy of the country as a whole. As quoted from the Homespun Lawyer's Speech, "Southern states produce, in foreign exports alone, upwards of $185,000,000 in value, nearly double that of the North's $95,000,000, no less than $87,000,000 flows through New York alone." The North relies heavily on the South for much of its production, so if the South's industry is destroyed, the North's will suffer disastrously as well. Lincoln acts like a child who demands his way, but that does not entitle him to destroy the entire nation.

Not only will the economy suffer, but people will die. Quoting from the True Kentuckian Speech, it was warned that "thousands of men, good men, who would undoubtedly die if war were to break out, when mothers, wives, and children will ask, 'Where is my son? Where is my

husband? Where is my father?'" Lincoln's clear direction towards war will undoubtedly lead to the destruction of countless innocent families. From Lincoln's perspective, these deaths will be no more than mere numbers; war will be used as a tool. He appears content to sacrifice the commoner, while conveniently maintaining his own distance from personal peril.

Furthermore, Lincoln has no right to ban secession since the right to secede is protected by the Constitution under the Tenth Amendment. It states: "The powers not delegated to the United States by the Constitution, nor prohibited by it to the States, are reserved to the States respectively, or to the people." This statement infers that the agreement between the government and the United States is more than a contract between the United States and a state, rather than a forced, unbreakable binding. This is a fundamental right each state must possess in order to protect themselves. The United States is not a barbaric kingdom where a province that wishes to leave is considered a rebellion. The states absolutely have the right to separate, just as people can move out of their countries and renounce their citizenship, or cities and towns can split into new entities, or even states can divide into new states, like West Virginia. But when it is at the level of the state, suddenly things are different? What would stop Lincoln from going as far as banning citizens from leaving? Would Lincoln then be considered a king? The Southern states are a minority, and secession is an absolute right, essential to protect ourselves from the North and from King Lincoln, who does not follow the Constitution.

In conclusion, we should distrust Lincoln for many valid reasons. He promises no interference with slavery despite a career explicitly dedicated to opposing it. He has gone out of his way to try and start a war that could potentially destroy the country's economy and lead to the deaths of millions, devastating countless families. Lastly, he is acting against the very Constitution he swore to uphold by imposing an unconstitutional ban on secession. We, Kentuckians, should see these actions for what they are, and our distrust is not merely suspicion but a clear-eyed recognition of the threat he poses to our way of life, our rights, our very existence and our property.